

SCALES SUCK - PHRYGIAN

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #173

There, I said it. Scales suck. Sure, play them for finger technique, for a warmup, or to learn a key area. But if you are trying to learn improvisation at a novice or intermediate level, scales suck. Does reciting the alphabet help you to speak or construct sentences? Nope, and neither will practicing scales get you to the next level in your improvisation study. Take the Phrygian Scale, one of the traditional modes that all jazz players eventually learn. Do you have any good Phrygian licks? Is Phrygian totally set in your ear? Likely not. Why is that?

#1 - C Phrygian Scale



#2 - E Phrygian Scale



So, if scale really aren't the best way forward, what should we do?

- 1) Learn MELODIES constructed with that scale (ie. licks and vocabulary).
- 2) Learn the context of the chords you are looking at. Everything flows from there.
- 3) How to do #1 and #2? Ask for help. Get a mentor or coach, and get good direction.

#3 - "Have You Met Miss Jones" (first 8 measures)

